

1340–44



The Strait of Gibraltar, where Marinid forces destroyed the Castilian fleet.

THE BATTLE OF RIO SALADO IS CONSIDERED, BY SOME, to be the defining battle of the **Reconquista**, ending forever the threat of **Islamic incursion** into the Iberian Peninsula from Africa. The **Marinid dynasty** of Morocco, which had overthrown the **Almohads** in the mid-13th century, gathered a vast force and destroyed the Castilian fleet in the **Strait of Gibraltar**. The Marinids then marched inland to the Salado River, where they were defeated by the Christian kings **Alfonso XI of Castile** (r. 1312–50) and **Afonso IV of Portugal** (r. 1325–57).

800,000

THE AMOUNT
IN FLORINS
OWED BY
EDWARD III

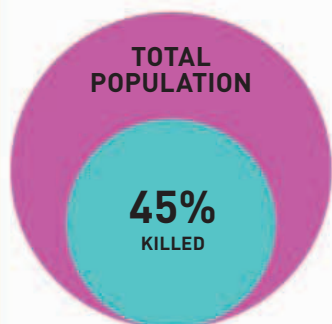
To finance his expensive war in France, **Edward III** of England (r. 1327–77) had taken out **huge loans** from Florentine bankers, especially the **Peruzzi family**. When the money ran out, Edward renounced his loan in 1342. With the king of Naples also defaulting on loans, the Peruzzi were bankrupted, throwing **Florence** into **economic chaos**. Walter de Brienne, the mercenary duke of Athens, was called in to take power in Florence but, eventually, a **mercantile oligarchy** took over.

1345–49



An illustration from Froissart's *Chronicle*, of 1346, depicts the Battle of Crécy, at which the English used mobile artillery for the first time.

HAVING GAINED MASTERY OF THE ENGLISH CHANNEL at the naval battle of **Sluys** in 1340, **Edward III** was free to invade France. He landed in **Normandy** in 1346 and took **Caen**, but retreated in the face of a huge French army. At bay, on the borders of the **forest of Crécy**, Edward took up a defensive position and inflicted a **crushing defeat** on the forces of Philip VI. This was largely thanks to the indiscipline and arrogance of the **French knights** and the effectiveness of the **Welsh** and **English longbowmen**. At the cost of a handful of casualties, **the English killed tens of thousands**, including the kings of Bohemia and Majorca, the duke of Lorraine, the count of Flanders, the count of Blois, eight other counts, and three archbishops. The English use of **combined aristocratic and yeoman forces** had produced a powerful new form of army. They would go on to **besiege Calais**,



Plague deaths
It is estimated that up to 45 percent of the total population of Europe was killed by the various waves of the *Black Death* plague.



THE BLACK DEATH

The effects of the Black Death are best recorded in Europe, where it had profound consequences. It depopulated the land, depressed the economy, checked intellectual and artistic progress, changed the social order, contributed to the end of feudalism, and triggered a wave of anti-Semitic pogroms on Jews, who were blamed for the pestilence, forcing many to migrate to Eastern Europe.

which fell in 1347, after a protracted siege. Also in 1347, the **Black Death** arrived in Europe. It is thought to have been carried initially by Genoese returning from the **Crimea**, where they had been exposed to it by infected Mongols. Transmitted by **fleas that were carried by rats**, the plague was spread by ship to the principal ports, and then to every corner of Europe and Western Asia. A large proportion of the population died.

1350–55

“WHATEVER THE WORLD FINDS PLEASING, IS BUT A BRIEF DREAM.”

Petrarch, Florentine scholar and poet, from *Canzoniere* Number 1 (c. 1352)

THE PAPACY WAS REFORMING ITS BUREAUCRACY and improving its finances under the Avignon popes. In 1348, **Clement VI** (1291–1352) bought **Avignon** from Joanne of Naples, and work continued on its papal palace. **Scholars and artists** were attracted to the papal city, briefly among them the Florentine **Francesco Petrarch** (1304–74), who had been crowned **poet laureate** in Rome in 1341. In 1351, Petrarch started to arrange his poems in **sonnet** form. He was also a scholar, whose translation and popularization of **Classical literature** contributed to the emergence of **humanism**, a new school of philosophy that would help to trigger the **Renaissance**.

In 1354, the Nasrid king of Granada, **Yusuf I**, was murdered by his son **Mohammed V** (1338–91) who took the throne. Under Mohammed, the **Alhambra**—the fortress-palace of Granada—was further developed, becoming a **treasure of Islamic architecture**.

The **Ottomans** were invited to **Gallipoli**, on the Dardanelles (the straits separating Asia from Europe), by John Cantacuzenus (c. 1292–1383), claimant to the **Byzantine throne**, to help in his attempt to gain power. Led by Orhan, the **Turkish dynasty** soon seized the peninsula, securing themselves a foothold in Europe.

Architectural jewel
The Court of the Lions is at the heart of the *Alhambra* palace, built by Mohammed V as the winter residence of the royal family.



1340 Battle of Rio Salado
1340 Blast furnaces for iron smelting used in Belgium
1344 Aegean Crusade takes Smyrna from the Turks
1342 Edward III renounces debts to Peruzzi bankers
1344 Mongols defeated by Poles and Hungarians

1346 Stephan Dushan IV crowned emperor of the Serbs
1346 Battle of Crécy
1346 Rebellion against the Sultanate of Delhi leads to foundation of Kashmiri kingdom
1348 Teutonic Knights defeat Lithuanian princes at Kovno
1347 Truce between English and French
1347 English take Calais
1347 Black Death strikes Genoa, Constantinople, Marseille, Cyprus, and ravages Naples, and ravages Western Asia
1348 Black Death hits Tuscany, France, Spain, and England

1351 War starts between Florence and Milan
1351 Second Siamese kingdom formed
1351 Petrarch starts to develop his sonnets
1351 Boccaccio completes his Decameron
1351 Zurich joins the Swiss Confederation, followed by Bern and other cities
1351 Acamapichtli becomes king of the Aztecs
1353 Champa battles to regain territory from Dai Viet
1354 Cola Di Rienzo, tribune and dictator of Rome, deposed and killed
1354 Ottomans seize Gallipoli